

Final Exam: Filipino Film Critique (*Birdshot* (2016))

I. Introduction

Birdshot, directed by Mikhail Red and released in 2016, is a gripping narrative film that explores the dark underbelly of the Philippine justice system. The film centers around a seemingly innocent act—a young girl accidentally shoots a Philippine Eagle, a symbol of justice—unraveling a chain of tragic events that leads to the death of her loved ones and highlights the dire consequences of poverty and corruption. I chose *Birdshot* after watching its suspenseful trailer, which hinted at themes of illegal armed groups in rural Philippines. However, as I delved deeper into the plot, I found myself captivated by the heart-wrenching realities depicted in the film, such as the harrowing stories of missing people, the struggles of a harassed family, and the extreme lengths to which individuals go to escape their circumstances. Ultimately, *Birdshot* resonated with me as it mirrors the harsh realities of poverty and corruption that permeate contemporary Philippine society.

II. Summary of the Plot

Birdshot follows the story of Maya, a young girl living in a remote area of the Philippines, who accidentally shoots a Philippine Eagle while exploring the nearby sanctuary. This seemingly innocent act sets off a tragic chain of events that exposes the grim realities of her community. As Maya grapples with the consequences of her actions, her father, Diego, becomes embroiled in a police investigation led by officers Domingo and Mendoza, who are searching for a group of missing farmers. The tension escalates as Diego's efforts to protect Maya lead him to confront the corruption within the local police force, resulting in violence and tragedy. The film's climax culminates in a harrowing confrontation between Maya and the police, forcing her to confront the harsh truths of her world and the loss of her loved ones. The story ultimately unveils the dark undercurrents of societal decay, leaving Maya in a hauntingly solitary position amid the chaos.

III. Critical Analysis

Theme: *Birdshot* profoundly explores the themes of poverty, corruption, and the failures of the justice system in the Philippines. The film illustrates how a single, seemingly innocuous act can lead to catastrophic consequences for those living in marginalized communities. Maya's accidental shooting of the Philippine Eagle serves as a metaphor for the broader societal issues at play, showcasing the fragility of innocence in a world rife with greed and exploitation. This theme remains highly relevant today, as many Filipinos continue to grapple with systemic injustices and the devastating effects of poverty. The film compels the audience to reflect on the societal structures that perpetuate such cycles of violence and despair.

The cinematography of *Birdshot* is a key strength, as noted by film critic Jaime Rebanal (Rebanal). Rebanal highlights the "impressive cinematography and beautifully tense atmosphere" (Rebanal), which effectively contrasts the film's setting and enhances the emotional impact. The use of natural lighting and wide shots, as I've previously noted, effectively captures the expansive yet isolating landscapes of the Philippine countryside, reflecting the characters' emotional states. Close-up shots of Maya's expressions convey her innocence and confusion, enhancing the audience's connection to her plight. The

contrasting visuals of the serene beauty of the sanctuary against the backdrop of violence and corruption further heighten the film's tension. This visual storytelling deeply enriches the narrative, allowing viewers to feel the weight of the characters' struggles.

Acting/Character Portrayals: The performances in *Birdshot* are a testament to the actors' ability to embody their characters' struggles authentically. Mary Joy Apostol delivers a poignant portrayal of Maya, capturing the character's innocence, courage, and eventual despair as the narrative unfolds. Her emotional range allows the audience to empathize with her journey from naivety to a harsh awakening. Likewise, Arnold Reyes as Diego effectively conveys the complexities of a father torn between protecting his daughter and confronting the grim realities of their world. The nuanced performances of the supporting cast, particularly the police officers Domingo and Mendoza, add depth to the narrative, highlighting the moral ambiguities within the justice system. Overall, the compelling character portrayals enhance the film's emotional impact and resonate with the audience.

Screenplay/Dialogue: The screenplay of *Birdshot* is characterized by its understated yet impactful dialogue. The conversations between characters often feel realistic and believable, reflecting the everyday speech patterns and emotional nuances of the characters. The dialogue effectively conveys the emotional tension and internal struggles of Maya and Diego. While not explicitly expositional, the conversations subtly reveal the characters' backgrounds and motivations. This understated approach enhances the overall narrative, allowing the visuals and the characters' actions to speak volumes. The film relies less on lengthy monologues and more on subtle exchanges that are both impactful and emotionally resonant.

Sound and Music: The sound design in *Birdshot* is masterful in its subtle yet impactful use of sound. The film utilizes a mix of ambient sounds—the rustling of leaves, the sounds of the countryside—which creates a sense of immersion and realism. This natural soundscape is punctuated by moments of intense sound, such as the gunshot that triggers the plot and the sounds of violence that emerge later. This careful use of contrasting sounds helps build tension and enhance the emotional impact of crucial moments. The music, while not overly prominent, serves to underscore the film's emotional beats, creating a mood of suspense and melancholy that complements the narrative effectively. The overall sound design adds significantly to the film's atmospheric and emotional power.

Symbolism/Imagery: *Birdshot* masterfully employs symbolism and imagery to enrich its narrative and deepen its themes. The Philippine Eagle, a national symbol, is ironically shot at the beginning, foreshadowing the loss of innocence and the corruption that permeates the film's setting. The vast cornfields symbolize the seemingly endless expanse of poverty and the feeling of isolation experienced by Maya and her family. The missing bus and the discovery of the bodies represent the systemic failure of the justice system and the hidden truths concealed beneath the surface of society. These powerful symbolic elements are woven tightly into the film's visual language, enriching the narrative and prompting viewers to interpret the events on a deeper level. By carefully observing these symbols, we gain a

more profound understanding of the film's central themes.

IV. Personal Reflection

Personal Reflection: Birdshot left a profound impact on me, both emotionally and intellectually. The film's unflinching portrayal of poverty, corruption, and violence evoked a range of emotions, from sadness and anger to a sense of helplessness. I found myself deeply moved by Maya's journey, her resilience in the face of tragedy, and her eventual awakening to the harsh realities of her world. The film challenged me to reflect on the societal structures that perpetuate such injustices and consider the systemic issues that contribute to human suffering. Birdshot served as a powerful reminder of the importance of empathy and social justice, prompting me to question the status quo and consider the ramifications of apathy in the face of overwhelming problems. The film's ending, though bleak, left me with a lingering sense of urgency, a call to action to advocate for change and to fight for a more just and equitable society.

V. Evaluation and Recommendation

Birdshot is undeniably effective in conveying its powerful message about poverty, corruption, and the failures of the justice system in the Philippines. The film's stark realism, compelling performances, and thought-provoking symbolism create a lasting impact on the viewer. While the film's bleak ending might not offer easy answers, it compels reflection and encourages critical engagement with the social issues it portrays. I would highly recommend Birdshot to audiences interested in thought-provoking cinema, particularly those who appreciate films that explore social and political themes with a realistic and unflinching lens. It's particularly relevant for those interested in Philippine history and culture and social justice issues. I give Birdshot a ★★★★★ rating out of 5 stars because of its powerful storytelling, exceptional performances, and its ability to leave a lasting impression long after the credits roll.

Works Cited:

Rebanal, Jaime. "Birdshot – Review."
Jaime's Reviews, 6 Apr. 2018,
<https://cinemafromthespectrum.com/2018/04/06/birdshot-review/>